

Our topic today can be introduced by a question raised by Marilyn Adams:

“Suppose for the sake of argument that horrendous evil could be included in maximally perfect world orders. ...

Would the fact that God permitted horrors because they were means to His end of global perfection make the participant's life more tolerable, more worth living for him/her?”

Many have thought not. A perfectly good being would not create beings whose lives were not worth living for them, just to add to the total greatness of creation.

A reasonable argument can be made that there are. Some children are born with conditions which make their lives very short and painful. Other people suffer such terrible evils that they question whether their lives were worth living.

The implicit assumption that Adams is making is that a good God would
make every human life worth living.

Suppose that there were some human being whose life was not worth living for him or her. Would a perfectly good being be justified in creating such a being, even if there were outweighing goods for others which could not be realized without his or her existence?

Are there people whose lives are not worth living for them?

It is natural at this point for the believer in God to appeal to the existence of life after death. If there were no such thing as life after death, how could lives of this kind have been worth living?

In this way, consideration of the argument from evil leads naturally into questions about the possibility of life after death.

What do the major monotheistic religions tell us about life after death?



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
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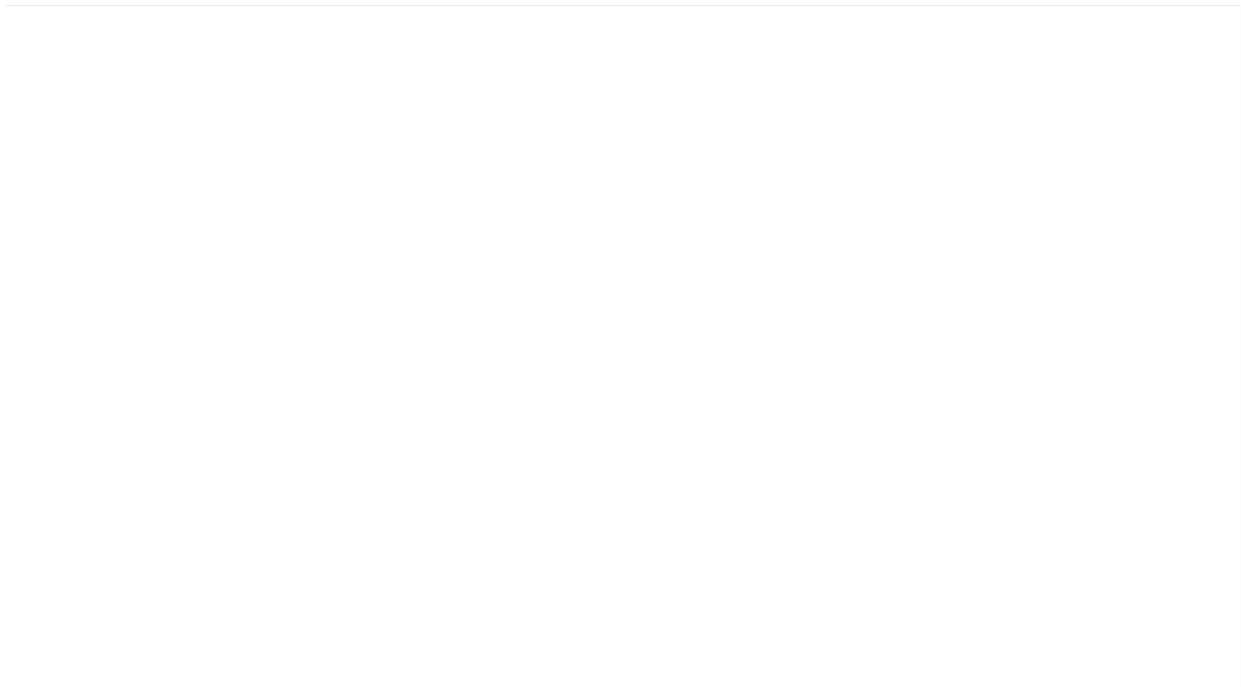
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The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

into external punishment, but the rights into

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

eternis!

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

perfectly good Good?

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by



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Before him will be gathered all the nations,

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the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

his glory, and all the angels with him . . .

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

and the wild sheep are then from another

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

but the rights are all in it.

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

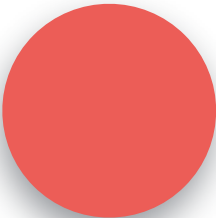
got to heaven forever, and some to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?





the existence of a perfectly good God.

traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

Let's try to layout Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

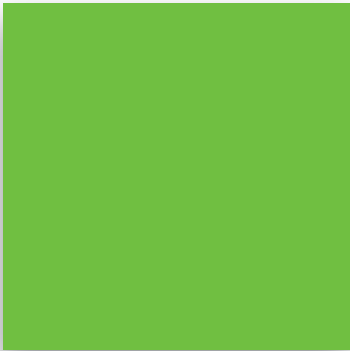
Let's call them the relevant properties.

heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,



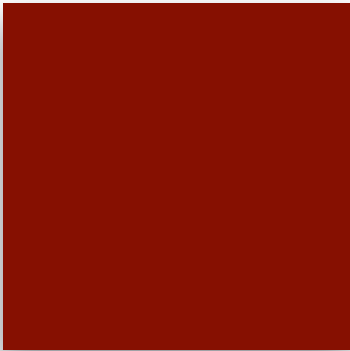












seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



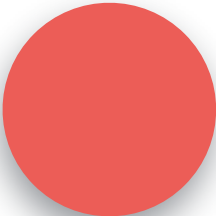
It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that





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